

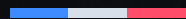
PARIS • 5 - 13 SEPTEMBER 2026

The Eiffel Tower Incident

BAPS, SETE and the Reputational Intelligence Brief



A plain reading of the evidence, and of how the world's media is telling the story. What is established, what is disputed, and how the controversy is being framed across France, India and international media.



INDEPENDENT OPEN-SOURCE ANALYSIS

Evidence cut-off 13 September 2026

Not commissioned, funded, reviewed or endorsed by BAPS, SETE, any union, authority or media organisation. Compiled from published reporting.

COVER PHOTOGRAPH • L. DE COCKBORNE / BOBOSTUDIO • USED WITH CREDIT

L. de Cockborne
BOBOSTUDIO

The Paris inquiry clears BAPS

No explicit request to exclude women; the fault lay inside the operator.

- The General Inspectorate of the City of Paris found “**no explicit request**” from the BAPS delegation to remove female staff. The request SETE received concerned “the lack of physical contact between religious figures and women”.
- That requirement was “progressively translated” into assigning men to posts, then dismissing or replacing women already in place. “Through word of mouth, the message was distorted,” the report said — a “**collective dysfunction**”, not a directive from the visitors.
- Consequence: SETE’s director general, Patrick Branco Ruivo, will step down by the end of 2026, after the operator’s own internal probe found “operational flaws and shortcomings”.

THE EVIDENTIARY CONCLUSION OF THE MATTER · SUPERSEDES EARLIER SNAPSHOTS

BAPS'S RESPONSE · 1 OCTOBER

“The investigation establishes ... that BAPS made no such request for women to be excluded along the visitor route.”

“BAPS wishes first to reiterate its concern for the employees affected by the events surrounding the visit.”

The inquiry resolves the central dispute: BAPS asked for no physical contact; the operator delivered that as the removal of women. The boundary was BAPS’s; the exclusion was SETE’s. Still unpublished: the exact original wording and the individuals in the chain.

Sources · Le Parisien, Hindustan Times, NDTV, BAPS statement — 1 October 2026

This page updates the brief after its original September snapshot. Independent analysis from published reporting. Not commissioned, funded, reviewed or endorsed by BAPS, SETE, any union, authority or media organisation. The cover date reflects the original compilation window.

Pujya Brahmaviharidas Swami

First live television interview on the Eiffel Tower row (Republic World).

- **Why BAPS stayed silent.** Spiritual discipline, he said: a rule laid down by Bhagwan Swaminarayan never to retaliate, even when abused or persecuted, but to pray for others instead.
- **“Anti-women” claims rejected.** He called the allegations “concocted and distorted”, noting that more than 60% of BAPS followers are women, and that a sadhu’s renunciation begins with his own mother and sister blessing his path.
- **On the “conspiracy” framing.** He declined to speculate, saying only that the truth has come out: independent investigations confirmed BAPS submitted no written request or formal demand to restrict female staff.
- **A message of forgiveness.** He relayed the spiritual leader’s call to “let bygones be bygones”, and closed with prayers for France, its president and the Eiffel Tower employees, hoping the new Paris temple stands for truth, transparency and trust.

Source · Full interview (YouTube), Republic World – October 2026

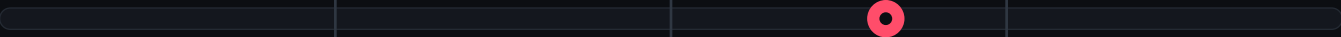
Reported remarks from a public interview; a party statement, included for completeness alongside the independent inquiry on the previous page. Not an endorsement.

The core fact is settled, and it closed against BAPS

SETE, the tower operator, confirmed the request itself. The question is no longer whether this happened. It is what exactly was asked, and who is responsible for how it was delivered.

What happened	A BAPS delegation of about 100 visited on Saturday 5 September, tied to the temple consecration the next day. Female staff, including subcontractors, were told to leave posts or avoid certain zones. In some posts men replaced them.
Confirmed	SETE stated BAPS asked for a visit limiting interactions with women, and that these conditions should not have been accepted. An admission against its own interest, which makes it strong evidence.
Disputed	The exact wording. Written or verbal. Who asked, who approved. Whether BAPS requested removal, or requested reduced interaction and SETE chose removal as the method.
Since 9 Sep	India's MEA formally distanced the government (“a matter purely between the entities concerned”). The story then split: it unites French politicians but divides the Indian diaspora, and a racism-against-Indians angle opened. Then, from 10 September, a counter-narrative in BAPS's favour: the mayor of Bussy-Saint-Georges praised BAPS's decade of local conduct while calling the tower episode “not acceptable”, and a 43-nation diplomatic open day was held at the Mandir, both carried by the IANS wire and Indian outlets, not the French mainstream.
Biggest exposure	The BAPS statement is non-responsive. “No one was denied access” addresses visitor access. The allegation is about employees being moved. Journalists have noticed.

WHERE THE EVIDENCE CURRENTLY SITS



Accommodation, badly executed BAPS asked for reduced interaction; SETE chose removal.	Request to exclude women A workplace arranged around employees' gender.
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REPUTATIONAL High Wire-carried into 20+ markets in 72 hours. Frame confirmed by the counterparty.	LEGAL Medium Employment duty sits with SETE as employer. BAPS exposure secondary, unproven.	COMMUNICATIONS High The published response does not address the actual allegation.	ESCALATION Med-High Two investigations pending. Any document restarts the cycle.
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5 Sep INCIDENT	1 day TOWER CLOSED	2 INVESTIGATIONS	30 OUTLETS READ	High OVERALL RISK
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02 · TIMELINE

A private visit became a national controversy in 72 hours

Red markers are the moments the trajectory changed. The four newest entries carry the story past the incident itself.

● WED 3 SEP	BAPS ceremony at the tower's foot, then a Seine parade Photographed by AFP, uncontroversial at the time. The imagery is now reused to illustrate the row.
● PRE-VISIT	The visit is arranged with SETE, terms still unresolved No public evidence of the date, channel, wording or authorship of the request. The largest evidentiary gap.
○ SAT 5 SEP	The visit. Female staff moved off posts, replaced in some cases by men About 100 people at the start of opening hours. Instructions covered employees and subcontractor staff.
● SAT 5 SEP	Indian Alliance Paris holds a press meeting on BAPS, hours before the visit A critical frame was already circulating among French journalists and the union before the incident.
● SUN 6 SEP	Temple consecrated at Bussy-Saint-Georges. Modi addresses by video The rite was men-only, relayed to ~7,000. Modi has said nothing about the Eiffel Tower.
○ MON 7 SEP	Staff vote to strike. The tower closes for the day Union wording: women sidelined, replaced and made invisible because of their sex. A letter used discrimination sexuelle.
○ MON 7 SEP	SETE confirms the request and says it should not have been accepted An admission against its own interest, weighted up accordingly. The narrative frame locks here.
● MON 7 SEP	BAPS Paris responds on X Says the arrangement was logistical, coordinated for the group's size, and that no one was denied access. Apologises for hurt.
○ 7-8 SEP	Political condemnation across the spectrum Gregoire: absurd, iniquitous, unacceptable. Berge: no dogma above the laws of the Republic. Two investigations ordered.
○ TUE 8 SEP	India's MEA distances the government from the row A matter purely between the entities concerned. The Indian state removes itself as a defender. New.
● TUE 8 SEP	Braun-Pivet and Chaturvedi raise the institutional level The National Assembly President and a Shiv Sena (UBT) MP both criticise. The Indian voice is personal, not governmental. New.
○ WED 9 SEP	The story splits: French unity, diaspora division, a racism warning France 24: the row unites French politicians but divides the Indian diaspora. A backlash-against-Indians angle opens. New.
● 10-11 SEP	Indian-language coverage turns critical; community response scales OpIndia's Gujarati and English editions both treat it critically; the Gujarati piece says the sect must not shift its rules onto society. New.
● 10 SEP	43-nation Indo-French Cultural Open Day at the Mandir Hosted by India's Permanent Delegation to UNESCO. Surfaced 12 Sep via the IANS wire and a BAPS release, not the French press. New.
○ 12-13 SEP	Counter-narrative: the mayor defends BAPS; inquiries still pending Mayor Dubosc praises BAPS's decade of local conduct and calls the tower episode not acceptable, awaiting the Paris inquiries. The wire version omits the incident. Neither inquiry has reported. New.

03 · NARRATIVE COMPARISON

The strongest case each side can make

Arguments paired by theme and scored one to four on evidentiary strength, not on how persuasive they sound. Blue is the case for BAPS, red the case against. Analyst coding, open to challenge.



11

TOTAL, FOR BAPS

18

TOTAL, AGAINST

0

PRO ARGS SCORING 4/4

The employer made the decision

SETE issued the instructions, apologised, and is the target of the investigations.

The request was made at all

An organisation asked a French monument to arrange staffing around employees' gender. The counterparty confirmed it.

A vow binds the monk, not women

Brahmacharya restricts the sadhu's own contact. Lay members are exempt.

The consequence was foreseeable

At a staffed monument, limiting interaction with women can only be done by moving women.

BAPS apologised within 48 hours

Public, and it did not dispute the staff's distress.

The response missed the accusation

Nobody said visitors were turned away. The complaint was about employees.

The three strongest defences are about SETE, about doctrine, or about missing evidence. None of them says BAPS acted well.

04 · EVIDENCE POSITION

Known, disputed, unknown

Twenty-four material facts, coded by evidentiary position. An empty box is not a defence: absence of a published document does not mean none exists.



Against interest: SETE's confirmation damages SETE, which is why it carries weight. Contradiction: a BAPS volunteer told AFP that saints have rules so men and women are separated, before the later gender denial.

05 · CENTRAL QUESTION

Did BAPS ask for women to be removed, or ask for something SETE delivered that way?

This decides whether the correct description is a badly executed accommodation or a request to exclude women.

WAS A REQUEST MADE?

Yes

Confirmed by SETE. Not denied by BAPS.

DID IT REFERENCE WOMEN?

Probably

SETE's wording says so. BAPS denies. No document.

WRITTEN OR VERBAL?

Unknown

Nothing public. Investigations will likely establish it.

DID SETE ACCEPT?

Yes

Admitted. Approver not named.

WERE WOMEN MOVED?

Yes

Staff, works council and CGT agree. The tower stayed open to tourists, so women were moved off posts, not sent home.

DID BAPS FORESEE IT?

Unknown

No evidence either way. Most consequential open question.

A request to limit interaction and a request to remove women are not the same act. But at a staffed monument, the first can only be delivered by doing the second.

Religious boundary vs workplace discrimination

A vow constrains the monk. It becomes something else when observance is delivered by changing another person's working conditions based on gender.

The vow is not misogyny. The implementation was still discrimination.

Accommodation vs exclusion

An accommodation adjusts the practitioner. Routing monks through low-staffed areas would not have caused this. An exclusion adjusts other people.

What was delivered was an exclusion. Whether BAPS asked for an accommodation is unproven.

Intent vs effect

The BAPS position is an intent argument. French law and opinion are effect-based. The staff statement is entirely about effect.

An intent defence does not engage an effect-based accusation.

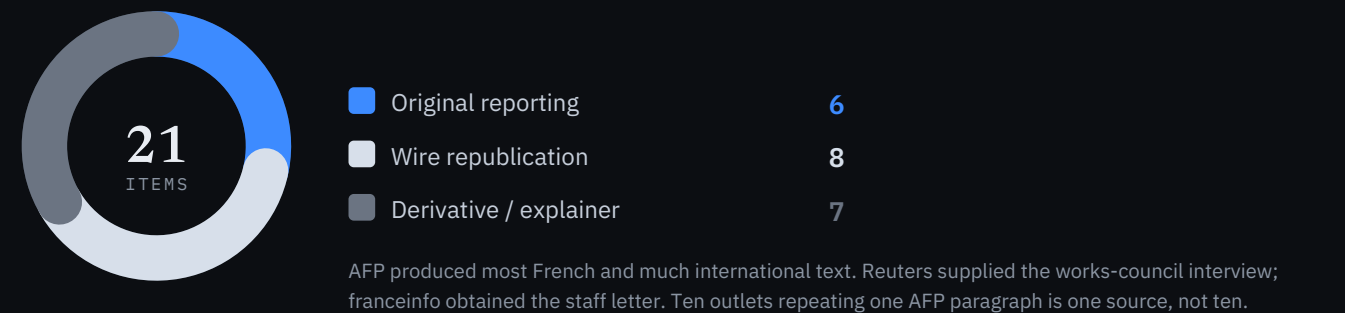
Who carries responsibility

The workplace duty sits with the employer, which is why the inquiries target SETE's internal approval.

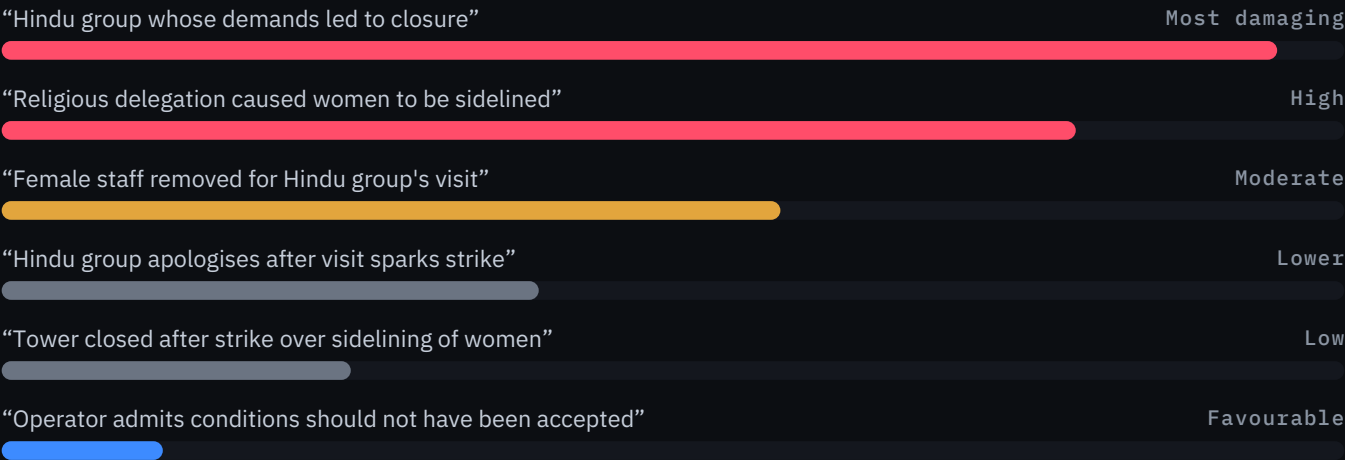
Legal responsibility most likely sits with SETE. Reputational responsibility is assigned to both.

Twenty-one items. Six original sources. One wire.

Not twenty independent investigations. A handful of originating accounts, amplified. Wide but shallow.



HOW THE HEADLINE SHIFTS THE BLAME



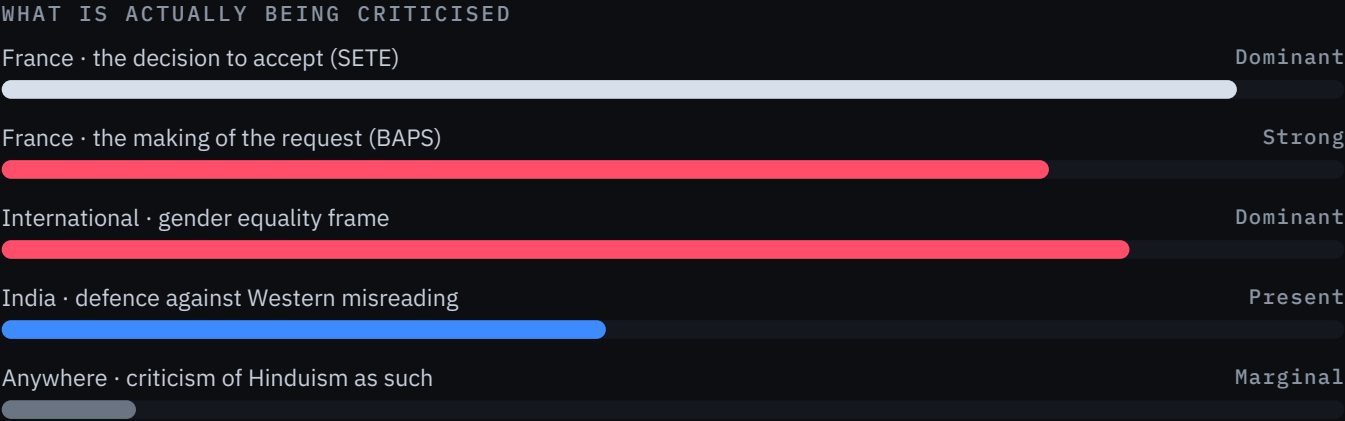
INDIAN, BROADCAST & EXPLAINER COVERAGE · ADDED 11 SEP

OUTLET	ORIGIN	STANCE	NOTE
OpIndia (EN & Gujarati)	IND	Critical	Both editions treat it critically; the Gujarati piece says the sect must not shift its rules onto society.
Outlook / The Week	IND	Neutral	Led on the government distancing rather than the incident.
Newslaundry / News Minute	IND	Critical	Own research into the vows and the political ties, not wire copy.
France 24 (diaspora)	FRA	Investigative	The most consequential piece published since 9 September.
RTBF / Euronews (TV)	BEL/EU	Critical / neutral	French-language and pan-European broadcast. Followed the wire frame.
Business Today TV	IND	Neutral	Indian television explainer of the row and the protest.
Religion Media Centre	UK	Neutral	Explainer. The most careful on the line between the vow and the workplace.

07 · SENTIMENT & STAKEHOLDERS

Coded positions, with the source count visible

No polling exists for a four-day-old story. These are coded counts of identified positions, not measurements of public opinion.

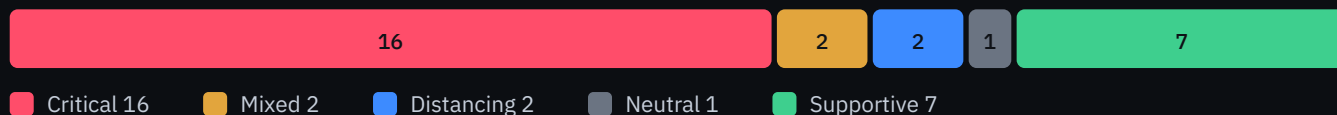


STAKEHOLDER	CURRENT POSTURE	WHAT DRIVES IT
Eiffel Tower staff & CGT	Opposition	Direct experience. Now negotiating a written VIP framework.
Works council (CSE)	Opposition	Wants guarantees, not apologies.
City of Paris	Opposition	Owns the monument. Two investigations running.
French government	Opposition	Equality minister engaged, but used “if confirmed”.
Ile-de-France region	Concern, exposed	Pecresse enabled the temple and attended festivities.
French far right	Instrumentalising	Fits an existing religion-and-Republic frame. Do not engage.
BAPS devotees, global	Support	Reading the incident as a misunderstanding of practice.
Indian diaspora, non-aligned	Split	Criticism of BAPS conservatism predates this incident.
Indian government	Neutral, distancing	MEA called it a matter between the entities. A step back.
Women's rights advocates	Opposition	A clear-cut case on their own terms.

08 • VOICES & STANCES

Who is saying what, and where they sit

Twenty-eight named voices were mapped across four countries. The thirteen highest-signal are below. Almost every supportive voice is inside the BAPS community and almost every critical voice outside it; the exception is the mayor of Bussy-Saint-Georges, a French official who now defends BAPS while condemning the incident.



WHO	CTRY	STANCE	WHY IT MATTERS
Ariel Weil	FRA	Conceded	SETE said the conditions should not have been accepted. The counterparty's admission, strongest evidence in the file.
Emmanuel Gregoire	FRA	Critical	Mayor of Paris. Called it absurd and iniquitous, ordered two investigations. His inquiry is the next news event.
Diane Davoine	FRA	Complainant	Works council. The originating account, quoted in almost all global coverage.
Yael Braun-Pivet	FRA	Critical	National Assembly President. Raises the institutional level of the criticism. New since 9 Sep.
Randhir Jaiswal	IND	Distancing	MEA spokesperson. "A matter purely between the entities." The most consequential shift since 9 Sep.
Mahua Moitra	IND	Strongly critical	MP, TMC. The sharpest-worded Indian political voice; tagged the French embassy.
Anish Gawande	IND	Strongly critical	Opposition spokesperson. Highest-reach single critical post; some claims contested in its own comments.
Indian Alliance Paris	FRA	Strongly critical	Calls BAPS a retrograde sect, and warns the affair must not become a pretext for racism. Both halves matter.
Sunita Viswanath	USA	Critical	Hindus for Human Rights. Frames the critique as Hindu-led, which makes anti-Hindu counter-claims harder.
Jay Thadeshwar	IND	Strongly supportive	Non-member. Highest-reach post on either side (~70k likes). The "earliest lift" detail is unverified.
Women of BAPS (~20)	GLOBAL	Supportive	First-person posts, one above 4,900 likes. The most credible asset BAPS has; weakest in absolute claims.
Rashmi Samant	IND	Mixed	Criticises and defends in the same piece: abroad, the host society meets the action, not the reasoning.
Yann Dubosc	FRA	Mixed	Mayor of Bussy-Saint-Georges. Praises BAPS's decade of local conduct yet calls the tower episode not acceptable and awaits the inquiries. The first French official to defend BAPS. New.

09 · DIASPORA & WHAT CHANGED SINCE THE 9TH

The story has stopped being about one morning

Since 9 September the controversy widened along three tracks with little to do with the Eiffel Tower. Then, from 10 September, a fourth opened that cuts the other way: an organised BAPS reputation push.

TRACK 1

Diaspora split

Indian groups in France are publicly divided. One side calls BAPS unrepresentative of Hinduism. The other is producing first-person defences at volume. A critique from Hindu organisations cannot be answered with a claim of anti-Hindu prejudice.

TRACK 2

Racism risk

The French far right has taken up the story. BAPS's own diaspora critics issued the racism warning themselves. This is the track BAPS controls least and can lose most on without doing anything further.

TRACK 3

Record revisited

Coverage has moved to the New Jersey labour case (US federal probe closed in 2025 without charges; civil suit continues) and to unproven land-allocation claims. Older material, new audience.

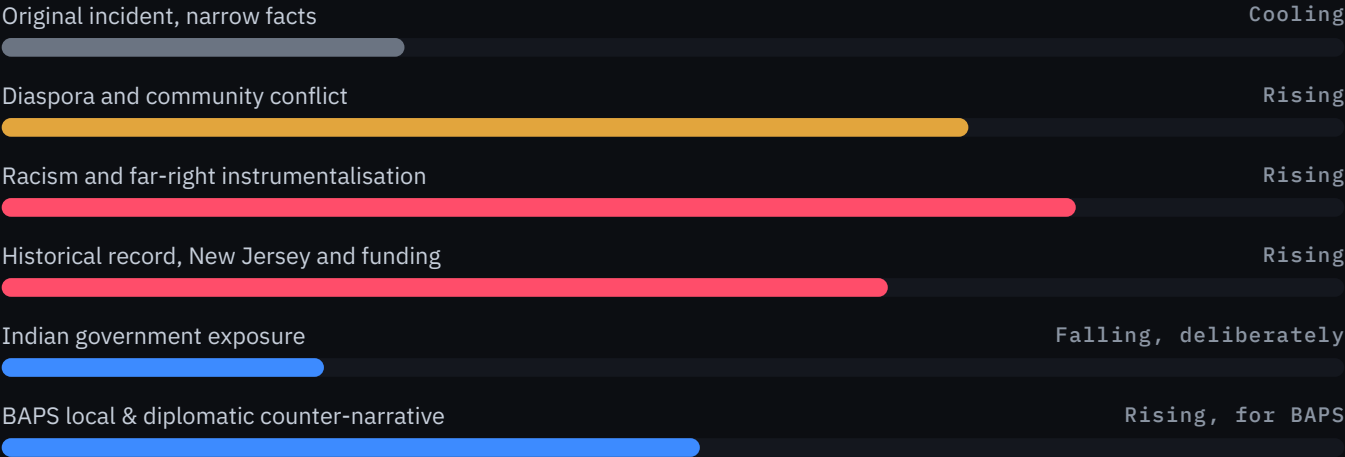
TRACK 4 · COUNTER-NARRATIVE (NEW)

The mayor defends BAPS, and the mainstream misses it

Mayor Yann Dubosc praises BAPS's decade of transparent local conduct, yet calls the tower episode not acceptable, backs gender equality and awaits the Paris inquiries. A 43-nation Indo-French Cultural Open Day, hosted by India's Permanent Delegation to UNESCO, was also held at the Mandir. Both travel only through the IANS wire and Indian and diaspora outlets, not the French mainstream that drove the criticism; the wire version even recasts the confirmed incident as rumours.

WHERE THE RISK NOW SITS, COMPARED WITH 9 SEPTEMBER

Direction of travel to 13 September, analyst assessment.



The one line: the original allegation is cooling, the diaspora and racism risks are still warming, and BAPS finally has a counterweight, the mayor's defence and the diplomatic open day. But it travels only through Indian and diaspora wire copy; until the French and Western mainstream carry it, the positive context stays invisible to the audience that formed the judgement.

10 · LANGUAGE & SENTIMENT

Two vocabularies that barely touch

The finding is not what either side says. It is that they are not using the same words at all. The critical vocabulary is about effect on a third party; the supportive vocabulary is about internal meaning and intent.

WHAT THE CRITICAL SIDE TALKS ABOUT

discrimination sidelined
public monument
laws of the Republic
why visit at all humiliated
double standard regressive
egalite removed invisible
far right workplace Hindutva

WHAT THE SUPPORTIVE SIDE TALKS ABOUT

brahmacharya
lived experience full picture
service mother's prayer
celibacy maryada
misunderstanding
not discrimination discipline
respect empowerment
boundaries proud

WHY THE SPLIT MATTERS MORE THAN THE VOLUME

Share of reviewed terms falling into each frame.

Critical terms describing effect on staff

Dominant

Supportive terms describing intent and meaning

Dominant

Terms used by both sides

Narrow

Supportive terms that engage the effect argument

Very narrow

Method: analyst-coded term frequencies across roughly 60 items in four languages, plus named X and Instagram posts and their comment threads. No platform API was used. Treat the bands as directional, a reading of the reviewed material rather than a measurement of public opinion.

11 · CONTRADICTIONS & RISK

Where the accounts diverge, and what would settle them

Was the request about gender?

SETE: a visit limiting interactions with women. BAPS: never rooted in gender, about size.
Better supported: SETE. If the concern were size, the instruction would have applied to all staff.

Access vs displacement

BAPS: no one was denied access. Staff: women moved off posts, replaced by men.
Both may be true. They answer different questions, and BAPS answered the easier one.

Was the monument privatised?

BAPS: normal opening hours. Some commentary: privatised. No union or SETE statement describes a closure.
One of the few places a BAPS clarification would be factually solid.

RISK HEATMAP

	FRANCE	INDIA	INTL	DEVOTEES
Reputational	Critical	Low	High	Low
Legal	Medium	None	Low	n/a
Political	Critical	Low	Medium	n/a
Partnerships	High	Low	Medium	n/a
Women	Critical	Medium	High	Medium
Under-30s	High	Medium	High	Medium
Interfaith	High	Low	Medium	Low
Venue access	Critical	None	Medium	n/a

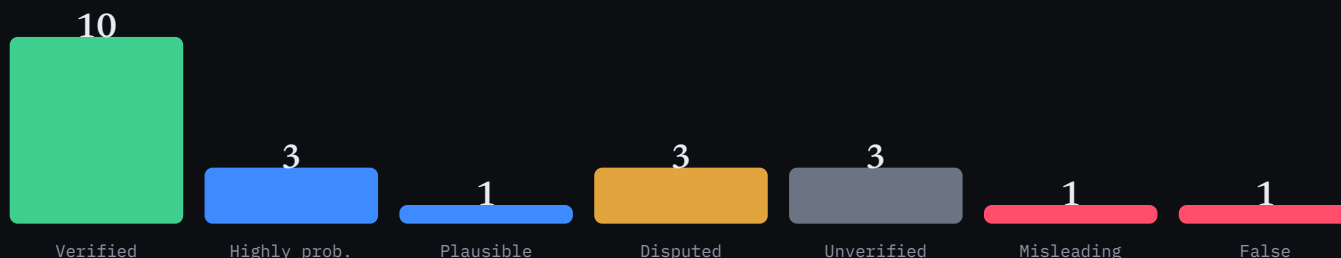
WHAT WOULD CHANGE THIS ASSESSMENT

Written request explicitly asking that women be removed	Much worse
Written request with no reference to sex	Much better
Evidence SETE proposed the removal method itself	Much better
Testimony a BAPS organiser saw the displacement	Worse
A precedent at another public venue	Much worse
Finding that SETE bore sole operational responsibility	Better

12 · CLAIM VERIFICATION

Key claims, assessed against the underlying source

Assessment reflects evidence strength, not whether a claim favours BAPS. Distribution across all twenty-two claims reviewed.



CLAIM	SOURCE	ASSESSMENT
Delegation of ~100 visited on 5 September	CBS/Reuters, AFP	Verified
BAPS requested the visit limit interactions with women	SETE to AFP	Verified
SETE accepted, later said it should not have	SETE to AFP	Verified
Female employees asked to leave posts	CGT, franceinfo	Verified
Men replaced women at some posts	Staff stmt, Reuters	Highly probable
Instructions extended to subcontractor staff	franceinfo	Highly probable
Tower closed 7 Sep due to the strike	La Presse / AFP	Verified
BAPS apologised	BAPS Paris on X	Verified
The request was never rooted in gender	BAPS Paris to CNN	Disputed
No one was denied access to the tower	BAPS Paris on X	Verified as stated
Sadhu vows restrict contact with women (monks only)	BAPS material	Verified
The 6 Sep rite was attended only by men	AFP on site	Highly probable
The request was made in writing	None	Unverified
BAPS knew women would be removed from posts	Critical commentary	Unverified
Women were prevented from working or lost pay	Social media	Misleading
Modi commented on the Eiffel Tower incident	Commentary	False as stated
Request was only to take the earliest lift (Thadeshwar)	Instagram reel	Unverified

13 · WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Every material claim traced to origin

All entries link to the article consulted in the interactive version. Reliability scale: 5 primary evidence, 4 official statement or direct interview, 3 multiple independent reports, 2 single report, 1 social claim.

Primary statements	SETE to AFP · BAPS Paris on X · BAPS Paris to CNN · staff statement via CGT · staff letter, franceinfo
Named interviews	Diane Davoine, works council · Denis Vavassori, CGT · Ariel Weil, SETE · BAPS volunteers to AFP
Official reaction	Mayor Gregoire · Aurore Berge · Valerie Pecresse · Yael Braun-Pivet · Marine Le Pen · India MEA
Media reviewed	AFP · franceinfo · Reuters · France 24 · Europe 1 · Public Senat · CNN · Bloomberg · Al Jazeera · IBTimes · OpIndia (EN & GU) · Outlook · The Week · Newslaundry · Organiser
Expert comment	Christophe Jaffrelot, Sciences Po, quoted by AFP
Legal reference	French Penal Code art. 225-1 to 225-4, Legifrance

SEVEN THINGS TO HOLD ON TO

- 1 The vow is real, and it binds the monk.**
Brahmacharya restricts the sadhu's own contact. It applies to monks, not lay members.
- 2 A personal boundary became a workplace question.**
At a staffed monument, a monk's boundary can only be delivered by moving women. That is the hinge.
- 3 The core fact came from the other side.**
SETE said BAPS asked to limit interactions with women, and that it was wrong to agree. An admission against interest.
- 4 Real questions remain open.**
Nobody has published the request's wording, who made it, or who approved it. Two investigations may answer.
- 5 The response created a second problem.**
"No one was denied access" answers a question nobody asked. It reads as avoidance, and journalists noticed.
- 6 The ground shifted after the 9th.**
India's MEA stepped back and the sharpest criticism now comes from inside Hindu and Indian organisations, which closes off the anti-Hindu framing entirely.
- 7 A counter-narrative has arrived, but only on the wire.**
Since 10 September the mayor of Bussy-Saint-Georges has defended BAPS and a 43-nation open day was held at the Mandir, the first shift in BAPS's favour. It travels through the IANS wire and Indian outlets, not the French mainstream that set the frame.

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS NOT

An independent reading of public reporting. Not commissioned, funded, reviewed or endorsed by BAPS, SETE, any union, authority or media organisation. Not legal advice. It is also not a defence document: where the evidence is unfavourable, it says so; where critics have overstated things, it says that too.

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